

Border Forge Instruction Manual

MAP + BLITZ + FORTIFY - v3 | 18 September 2026

Choose your setup

What this manual covers

This guide covers the v3 family-play version of Border Forge, including the visual phone map, single-round attacks, blitz, advisor support and fortification. Use the shared computer or TV as the main view. Phones submit choices; the computer applies the game rules.

The goal

The standard game is won by the last surviving commander. Capture territory, defend your borders and use reinforcements to keep your position strong. Strongholds and scientific breakthroughs provide advantages; they do not replace domination as the win condition in the current standard profiles. Special scenarios alter conditions, so read their setup descriptions and the computer's Rules panel.

Same room with phones

Use Local / Hot-Seat on the computer. Each human commander can have an assigned phone. Choose up to four human commanders, with no more than five commanders total including AI opponents. A TV is optional: cast or mirror the computer using your usual equipment. The game does not supply its own casting system. Phones and the host need internet access.

One computer without phones

The full desktop controls remain available. People can take turns at the computer in Local / Hot-Seat mode. Follow handoff screens so the correct person takes the next turn.

Remote players on computers

Use Online - Host Room and Online - Join Room. The host chooses the human count and creates the online room; other computer players enter its room code. These are separate from Phone setup rooms. This v3 phone-controller release does not combine remote computer players and phone controllers in the same game. Cross-location play should be checked with your intended players before scheduling a long session.

Current play links

Game: <https://borderforge-controller-test.onrender.com/>

Phone controller: <https://borderforge-controller-test.onrender.com/controller.html>

These are the family test links. Confirm the phone page displays MAP + BLITZ + FORTIFY - v3. An older page or older itch.io build may not include these controls.

Set up and begin a game

Recommended first session

On the computer, select Local / Hot-Seat, Frontier Command, Quick game length and Quick Deploy. Choose the number of humans and AI opponents. Turn off Guided first-game tutorial for this initial controller session, since computer overlays can interrupt phone actions. For a solo practice game, use one human and one AI.

Rules and settings

Core Conquest is the simpler ruleset. Frontier Command adds terrain, strongholds, specialists, research, diplomacy and events when enabled. AI difficulty changes decision-making; Player Assistance changes the human economy. A map seed lets you return to the same battlefield setup. Use the setup descriptions for scenarios and escalation choices. Strategic Deploy is not supported by the phone action list; use Quick Deploy for controller sessions.

Create the phone room

Open Phone setup on the computer and choose Connect a phone. Give players the invitation link or displayed eight-character code. On each phone, enter a name and join. The Send test signal button checks the connection only; it is not a gameplay action.

Assign the commanders

Choose Start game with current settings on the computer. One phone and one human are assigned automatically. For multiple humans, open Phone setup and assign each named phone to the intended commander. A commander can have only one assigned phone. Confirm assignments by comparing the commander name on each phone with the shared board.

Capital selection and handoffs

If research is enabled, players choose capitals during opening setup. On your turn, tap an owned territory, choose its capital action and confirm. With multiple human commanders, the host must confirm handoff screens on the computer. A waiting phone displays whose turn it is; it cannot act for another player.

Learn the displays

The shared board shows ownership colors, army counts, regions and terrain. The phone shows a recognizable copy of that board with tappable nodes. Tap near a territory's army marker. White marks the selected source; yellow highlights offered choices. Zoom in when needed and scroll the enlarged map. The text fallback remains under All moves · text controls.

Reinforce and attack

Reinforcements

At the start of a normal turn, receive armies based on territory holdings, complete-region bonuses and active rules. The basic territory allowance is one army per three territories, rounded down, with a minimum of three; settings and events can modify the total. Use the displayed remaining count. Tap an owned territory, choose an amount within its limits, then confirm. Repeat as needed.

Move into the attack phase

After placing all armies, choose Continue to attacks and confirm. Required card trades may need attention on the computer first. You may skip attacking by choosing Finish attacking; you do not have to attack every turn.

Choose an attack

Select an owned source with at least two armies, then a highlighted adjacent enemy. Ownership, adjacency and truces affect legal choices. Events can also prevent an otherwise plausible attack. Consult the computer if an offered attack produces no movement or combat.

Single combat round

Attack one round resolves one roll of combat. It does not mean that you send exactly one army. The engine rolls up to three attacking dice and up to two defending dice, depending on army counts. Highest dice are compared first; the defender wins ties. Terrain, specialists, research and escalation can change the outcome. Losses are not guaranteed to be one army at a time.

Blitz until exhausted

Blitz repeatedly attacks the same target using the desktop game's routine. It stops when the target is captured, the attacker cannot continue, or another built-in stopping condition applies. It can exhaust the attacking force. The phone offers standard blitz; additional desktop combat controls such as Controlled Blitz are not exposed on the phone.

Capture and continue

After single-round combat, the same source and target remain selected if the attack is still legal. After capture, complete any advance prompt by choosing how many armies move into the captured territory. Blitz may handle movement automatically. Watch the shared board before choosing another action. Capture at least one territory during a turn to earn a card under the game's card rules.

Fortify and use the advisor

Enter Fortify

Choose Finish attacking and confirm. You are moving existing armies, not placing new reinforcements. You receive one fortification action for the turn.

Choose a connected destination

Tap a friendly territory with at least two armies. Then tap a highlighted friendly destination. It need not be directly adjacent, but there must be a continuous path through territories you own. Enemy territory breaks the path. If a source has no legal destinations, choose another source or skip fortification.

Choose the amount

The maximum is the source army count minus one. For example, a source containing six armies can move at most five. Enter a whole number within the displayed bounds. The computer rechecks ownership, connection and available armies when it receives the move.

Confirm and end the turn

Choose Move armies & end turn and review the confirmation, then confirm. Cancel lets you reconsider before sending. A successful move automatically ends your turn; you cannot make a second fortification. Specialists move proportionally under the existing game rules. To make no move, use End turn without fortifying. The next commander then takes over.

Read the advisor

The advisor gives an action and a reason. Its recommendation may address border defense, attack opportunities or moving armies toward an exposed area. Estimates and suggested moves do not guarantee success. Watch the board and use your own judgment about how much risk to take.

Review a recommended move

For supported reinforcement, attack, fortification and phase actions, Review recommended move selects the relevant controls. For reinforcement or fortification, it also fills in a suggested amount. Change the amount if desired and confirm explicitly. The review button alone does not execute the move. For unsupported advice, the phone directs you to the computer.

Example

The advisor proposes moving four armies from an interior territory to a border territory. Review the move, check that the source keeps enough defenders, adjust the amount if needed, then confirm. The destination gains those armies and your turn ends. You cannot return to attacking after making that fortification.

Computer controls and recovery

Decisions still made on the computer

Use the computer for card trades, research purchases and final research, specialist promotions, diplomacy and truce offers, and other special dialogs. Complete hot-seat handoffs there as well. An open dialog or active autoplay can block phone commands; finish the dialog or pause autoplay before continuing.

Cards and advanced systems

Trade a valid card set during Reinforce for bonus armies; the game indicates when a trade is required. Research spends resources for a later combat advantage, and capitals matter to research. Specialists alter combat and move with armies according to the rules. Diplomacy can create temporary non-aggression pacts. Costs and available actions depend on the active rules and state: read the computer's displayed controls and Rules panel before committing.

Saving and breaks

Save the campaign from the computer. Save/export controls belong to the host game, not the phone. A campaign save does not preserve the controller room or phone assignments. Keep the host tab open and the computer awake during play. After loading or restarting a campaign, check assignments again; a new room may be needed. Avoid deploying an update in the middle of a family session.

A phone is waiting or cannot act

Check the commander name and whose turn it is. Ask the host to check for a handoff, open dialog, required card trade or active autoplay. If no map appears before the game starts or before assignment, finish setup first. If the page remains text-only, check the v3 version label and refresh the phone after the correct version is deployed.

A connection drops

Keep the computer game open. Return to the phone's browser tab and allow automatic reconnection. If a move is rejected as outdated, use the newly displayed choices; do not repeatedly submit the old action. If the room has closed or expired, the host should create a new room, then players join and are reassigned. Service restarts clear rooms. Phone sleep prevention and durable host recovery are not implemented.

What to report after a family game

Note the version, number of human players and phones, the phase, what each screen said, and whether the shared board changed. Report any wrong commander assignment, duplicate move, stuck handoff, failed reconnect or unexplained army count. Multi-phone family play is the next useful validation step; a successful solo session does not establish every multiplayer case.